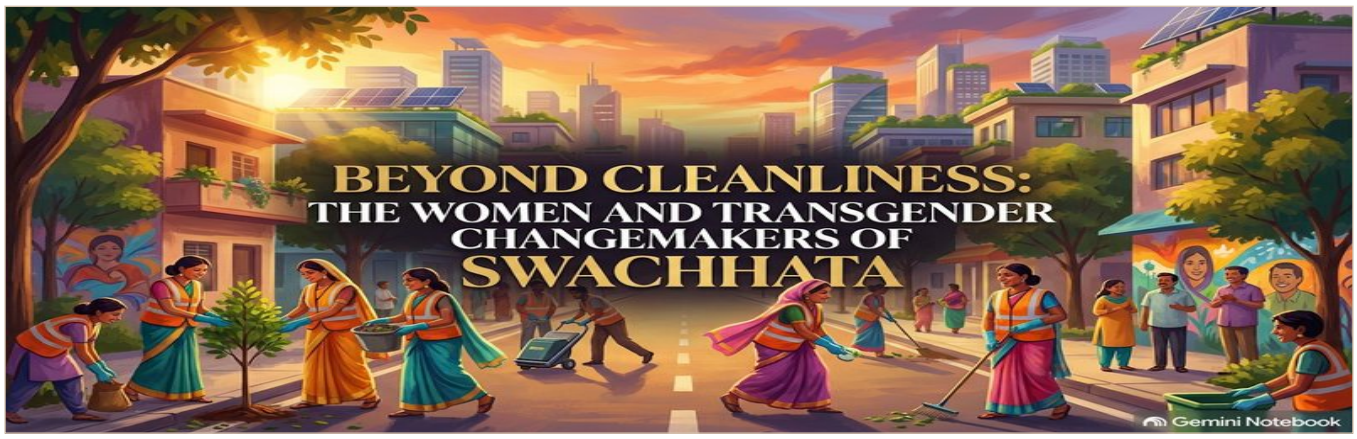


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Founder & Chief Mentor

[ESSAY • GS PAPER II – GOVERNANCE & SOCIAL JUSTICE • GS PAPER III – ENVIRONMENT & SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT • GS PAPER I – INDIAN SOCIETY • GS PAPER IV – ETHICS, INTEGRITY & APTITUDE]

Publication Date: 04/10/2026

Beyond Cleanliness: The Women and Transgender Changemakers of Swachhata



The article highlights how women and transgender persons are transforming Swachhata into a pathway for livelihoods, dignity and social inclusion. Through innovative waste management, community participation and inclusive sanitation initiatives, these changemakers demonstrate how cleanliness can drive sustainable and equitable development.

Beyond Cleanliness: The Women and Transgender Changemakers of Swachhata

Syllabus areas:

Essay

GS Paper II – Governance & Social Justice

GS Paper III – Environment & Sustainable Development

GS Paper I – Indian Society

GS Paper IV – Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude



A clean city is often defined by what is no longer visible—waste on streets, blocked drains and inadequate sanitation. Behind this transformation are women turning waste into livelihoods and transgender persons gaining professional roles in sanitation. Swachhata Hi Seva 2026 promotes this spirit through citizen participation, dignity, enterprise and collective responsibility towards a Swachh and Viksit Bharat.

When waste become a livelihood:

Around gaushalas and dairies, cow dung can become a waste-management challenge, especially when it enters drains and sewage channels. In Krishna Vihar Colony, Loni, Uttar Pradesh, a group of women found an innovative solution by using cow dung to make incense sticks and Loban cups. What began with 8–10 women gradually became a livelihood opportunity for many more.

A woman from the Loni Nagar Palika Parishad supported the initiative by connecting the producers with gaushala owners for a steady supply and effective utilisation of cow dung. During the summer, when demand for incense products peaks, the initiative employs around 40–50 women, providing livelihood, dignity and economic opportunity. The Nagar Palika Parishad also earns up to 25% revenue from product sales.



The products use around 30–35% dry cow-dung powder, reducing the requirement for wood sawdust and promoting reuse. They are supplied across India, including Delhi, Mumbai, Punjab, Gujarat and Hyderabad, and have also reached Mauritius and South Africa.

The initiative is now exploring cow-dung fuel for cremation grounds and havans, along with biodegradable flower pots that can return to the soil as manure. Thus, waste is transformed into livelihood, enterprise and environmental value.

From waste collectors to waste leaders:

In Patna, Bihar, women are breaking traditional conventions and giving cleanliness an inclusive dimension. At the city's Pink Material Recovery Facility (MRF), women play a central role in waste management under a female supervisor. The facility processes dry and wet waste, handling around 2 tonnes of dry waste and 1.5 tonnes of wet waste daily.

The Pink MRF was established to create employment opportunities for women in waste management. Patna Municipal Corporation supported the initiative, enabling the facility to be set up within three months. Through the **'Cash for Waste'** initiative, citizens can bring dry waste and receive payment, creating incentives for community participation while giving waste economic value.



Patna has also transformed old, unusable vehicles into **mobile Pink Toilets**, demonstrating the principles of the **3Rs—Reduce, Reuse and Recycle**. Together, these initiatives link sanitation with women's empowerment, environmental sustainability, community participation and livelihood opportunities, showing how inclusive participation can strengthen urban cleanliness.

Women who carry cleanliness into their communities:

Women are transforming Swachhata by strengthening community participation. In Bhopal, 250 women brand ambassadors support cleanliness and waste management, while **'Bartan Banks' across 25 wards** promote reusable utensils and reduce single-use plastic. A 60-member **'Swachhata Kitty Group'** contributes monthly towards community cleanliness activities.



In Uttarakhand, the **'Bainni Sena'**, comprising 570 women across 57 groups, monitors cleanliness, spreads awareness and connects citizens with municipal authorities. In Shillong, the **Lynnehskhem Self-Help Group** collects wet waste

and converts biodegradable waste into compost, creating livelihoods through rehabilitation and training. Together, these initiatives turn Swachhata into a shared culture of care, participation and sustainability.

When Inclusion Changes the Face of Sanitation:

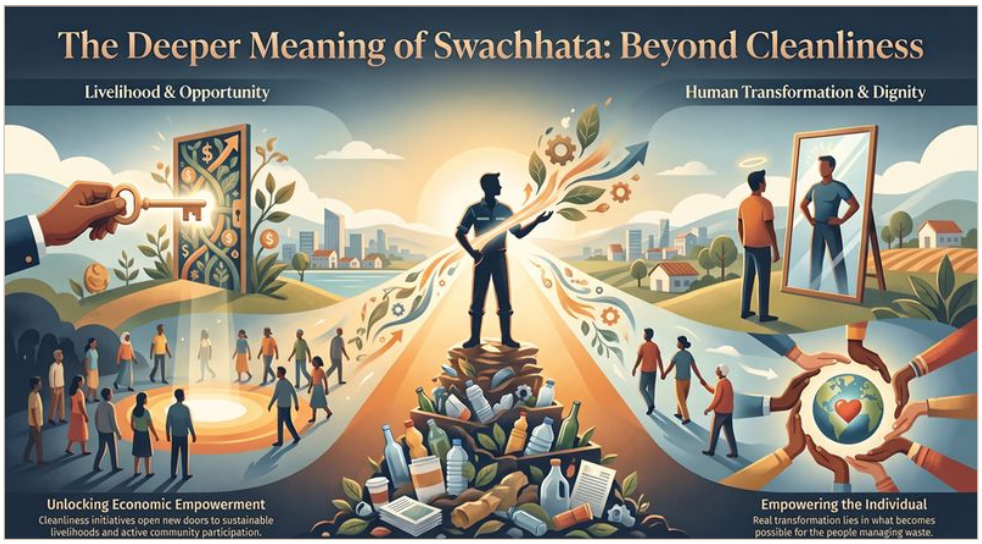
In Odisha, transgender persons are gaining professional roles at the heart of urban sanitation systems. The initiative began in Cuttack, where the Municipal Corporation formed a transgender Self-Help Group, provided training and entrusted its members with operating and maintaining a Septage Treatment Plant. The model later expanded across Odisha, with Urban Local Bodies partnering with Self-Help Groups in **Faecal Sludge and Septage Management (FSSM)** and solid waste management.



In Bhubaneswar, the **Swikruti Self-Help Group** operates and maintains a **75-KLD Faecal Sludge Treatment Plant (FSTP)** at Basuaghai after receiving technical and managerial training. The initiative has strengthened professional identity, confidence and social recognition among members. The Bhubaneswar Municipal Corporation has also involved transgender groups in operating seven cesspool vehicles, with minimum applicable wages and training in health, hygiene, personal protective equipment and desludging protocols. Odisha's initiative demonstrates how inclusive livelihoods can advance both sanitation and social empowerment.

The Deeper Meaning of Swachhata:

These stories show that Swachhata can do more than create cleaner surroundings. It can open doors to livelihoods,participation, and recognition. The real transformation lies not only in what happens to waste, but in what becomes possible for the people who manage it. When people once pushed to the margins find a place at the heart Of Swachhata, cleanliness takes on a deeper meaning. It becomes a shared effort, shaped by dignity, opportunity and a sense of belonging.


The Deeper Meaning of Swachhata: Beyond Cleanliness
Livelihood & Opportunity
Human Transformation & Dignity
Unlocking Economic Empowerment
Cleanliness initiatives open new doors to sustainable livelihoods and active community participation.
Empowering the Individual
Real transformation lies in what becomes possible for the people managing waste.